LETTER FROM THE EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

The new idiom of luxury explores travel not merely as an escape from routine but as a playful conflation of ritual and retreat. Almost on cue, the *Spice* travel issue reimagines getaways as a blur of boundaries, between the found and the familiar. After all, it isn't what you see but what you remember that becomes impossible to ignore.

Beyond the Prime Minister's clarion call to focus our wanderlust inwards, international travel in the times of war comes with its own calculation of inconveniences, from flight disruptions to lengthy visa processing and a weakening rupee. The result has proved to be a bonanza for domestic tourism, with a growing appetite for destinations that offer both discovery and convenience. As travellers venture beyond traditional circuits, the *Spice* cover story *"The new Geography of Luxury Travel"* explores this changing paradigm. With affluent Indians choosing immersion over opulence through experiential journeys, a new focus on pilgrimages, wellness itineraries, and wildlife safaris is headlining travel.

According to MakeMyTrip's Pilgrimage Travel Trends 2024-25 report, hotel bookings across 56 religious destinations rose 19% year-on-year, while premium accommodation bookings priced above ₹10,000 a night grew by 23%. At the Taj Group's Anand kashi by the Ganges, in Rishikesh, average room rents are priced at ₹38,800, per night, going up to over ₹50,000 in season. Also, it's the changing demographic that's truly interesting; while millennials account for nearly 6 in 10 pilgrimage travellers in FY26, almost 1 in 6 pilgrims is now from Gen Z.

Beyond the traditional wildlife circuit, where nature-led luxury experiences are all the rage, under the radar destinations such as the Jawai Leopard Conservation Reserve, are the newest magnets for wildlife enthusiasts. Jawai boast the world's highest density of leopards; a new ITC Storii, Jawai, Rajasthan, resort opened here in March, while a Postcard Hotels property is all set to launch by October. In the Northeast as well, it isn't just local hotel groups that are turning the spotlight on the region.

The Taj group is among the biggest players with 21 hotels across the region, including 12 currently under development. The Leela Palaces, Hotels and Resorts also plans to step in with the opening of The Leela Sikkim in 2028.

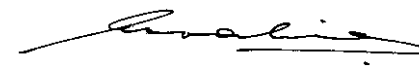
While cheering for homeground advantage, *Spice* offers an alternative stake in the great football migration, with exciting itineraries for a blowout once post-match celebrations wrap up. From The Ritz-Carlton's newest super yacht, to tequila traipsing across blue agave fields in Mexico, the after-party continues as we drop anchor on the other side of the Atlantic, checking in at The Chancery Rosewood, one of London's newest and most notable architectural masterpieces. The reinvention of the former US embassy into a public hospitality destination, offers an all-suite property which includes eight restaurants and bars. Tobi Masa marks the London debut for Masayoshi 'Masa' Takayama, one of the most influential Japanese Chefs, while Carbone, the New York City cult favourite, also launches its first European outpost at this historic venue.



The Postcard in the Durrung Tea Estate, Assam, (Above) is evidence that experiential travellers are seeking to explore the North East, a relatively undiscovered slice of the country.

Staying with the UK's legendary vestiges, the newly launched Range Rover Sport SV Edition Two, promises to haul its two-and-a-half-tonne SUV body from 0-100kmph in 3.8 seconds. Whether this engineering feat is even more impressive on Indian roads, is a question for the *Spice* test drive.

Luxury has always been about access. Today, it is increasingly about discovery. We hope this issue inspires your next journey, whether it takes you across the world or simply allows you to see India with fresh eyes.



(Aroon Purie)